

CHARLES NUNGESSER

FRENCH ACE CHARLES NUNGESSER (1892–1927) was a fearless individualist in love with danger, and perhaps more than half in love with death. A champion boxer and swimmer, he began the war in the cavalry but soon transferred to the air service. Flying for the N65 squadron based in

Nancy, his bravery and flare soon

became legendary,

achieving 10

victories



during the battle of Verdun. In 1916, he crashed while testing a new aircraft, breaking both legs; the joystick smashed into his face, breaking his jaw and perforating his palate. Two months later, still walking on crutches, he was back in the air. More crashes followed, and more injuries. By the summer of 1917 he was so ill he had to be carried to his cockpit. His decorations included the Military Cross and Legion d'Honneur. Yet he never gave up trying to improve his score, and ended up with 43 victories.

His death in 1927 has remained a mystery, after his biplane, *L'Oiseau Blanc*, was lost at sea between Paris and New York during an attempted nonstop Atlantic crossing.

SKULL AND CROSSBONES

Nungesser decorated his Nieuport with a macabre array of symbols of mortality, including skulls, coffins, and candlesticks. He miraculously survived World War I, only to disappear, along with his airplane, in 1927.

that had been drummed into them. For instance, every trainee was told that if his engine failed after takeoff, he should under no circumstances attempt to turn back to the airfield. But hundreds did just that, going into a fatal spin.

When losses at the front were heavy, replacements were sent to combat units with 10 hours or fewer of flying time to their credit. This was not a certain death sentence, but came close. Any aircraft of the time was difficult to fly. Basic errors in landing and takeoff cost hundreds of lives. And in the air you needed to learn quickly what maneuvers your aircraft was able to stand without falling apart. Many fighter pilots started their combat careers with a stint as an observer or reconnaissance pilot. Those sent directly into fighter units at first had little idea what was going on around them. Some testified to going through their first dogfight without seeing the enemy at all – everything happened too fast. The lack of radio contact between aircraft meant that once a pilot was in the air, even flying in formation, he was essentially on his own. Some squadrons protected novices, but others developed a ruthless attitude toward them, regarding them as disposable. They were given the unit's worst machines and left to fend for themselves.

Combat style

As the war went on, all sides got better at readying pilots for the shock of the war, but it was the Germans who made the most effort to prevent

